WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

ANTI-SHIP MISSILES AND MISSILE DEFENSE

Although anti-ship missiles were trialed to some degree during World War II, it was only during the late 1950s and 1960s that they began to challenge gunnery as the primary weapon of combat vessels. Pioneering missiles such as the SS-N-2 Styx proved their worth in action, most notably sinking the Israeli destroyer *Eilat* in 1967, and inspired the US Navy to develop its own Harpoon missile during the 1970s. By the 1980s all major world navies had equipped themselves with ship-launched missile systems plus, in many cases, electronic countermeasures (ECM) to combat enemy missile threats. Among the more effective anti-ship missiles developed in the 1980s, the Exocet gained particular notoriety in its air-launched form during the Falklands War. Most such missiles use active radar or infrared homing systems, and some of the longer-range examples can hit targets well over 62 miles (100 km) away. Even terrorist units have used missiles against ships—in 2006 a Hezbollah unit hit and damaged an Israeli corvette with a Chinese-made C-802 missile.

Sea Sparrow
Fitted on board many US and NATO warships, the RIM-7 Sea Sparrow is a lightweight, radar-guided missile system used to provide point defense against air attack, incoming missiles, or small surface craft.



Excocet MM38 ship-launched missile
The French-built Exocet missile is designed to target large warships—the Type-42 destroyer HMS *Sheffield* was sunk by an Exocet during the Falklands War.

(two Komar class and one Osa class) moved out from harbor and fired their Styx missiles, well beyond the range of the Gabriels. As the missiles approached the Israelis deployed their jamming systems and chaff—both worked, and the missiles splashed harmlessly into the sea. The Israelis now closed to range, and a missile exchange ensued in which all three Syrian boats were destroyed.

ARAB-ISRAELI WARS



THE BATTLE OF LATAKIA

Date	October 7, 1973
Location	Off the port of Latakia, Syria
Result	Israeli victory

COMBATANTS

ISRAEL	SYRIA

COMMANDERS

Benjamin Telem	Fuad Abu Zikry

FORCES

Ships: 6 missile boats	**Ships:** 3 missile boats, 1 torpedo boat, 1 minesweeper

LOSSES

Men: none **Ships:** none	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** 3 missile boats, 1 torpedo boat, 1 minesweeper

INDO-PAKISTAN WAR

1971 INDO-PAKISTAN WAR



Date December 3–16, 1971
Forces Indians: c.100 ships; Pakistanis: c.40 ships
Losses Indians: 1 frigate; Pakistanis: 1 destroyer, 1 minesweeper, 1 submarine, 4 patrol boats

Location Off coast of East Pakistan and Karachi

The two week-war between India and Pakistan over the separatist movement that led to the creation of Bangladesh, featured some of the largest naval engagements seen in Asia since World War II. The priority for the Indian navy was to stop the flow of supplies between East and West Pakistan. The Indian aircraft carrier *Vikrant* was dispatched to blockade the port of Chittagong in East Pakistan, its Sea Hawk aircraft seriously damaging the harbor facilities. The Pakistani submarine *Ghazi*, sent to oppose the *Vikrant*, was sunk, possibly by Indian depth charges. On December 3, India launched a night-time attack on Karachi harbor in West Pakistan, sinking a destroyer and crippling several other vessels.

The short conflict confirmed the superiority of the Indian navy. India lost only one major vessel, the former British frigate *Khukri*, torpedoed by a Pakistani submarine, and largely achieved its goal of a naval blockade.

SRI LANKAN CIVIL WAR

SRI LANKA AND THE SEA TIGERS



Date 1984–present
Forces Sri Lankans: c.50 combat, support, and patrol vessels in 2008; Sea Tigers: unknown
Losses Sri Lankans: 30 gunboats, 1 freighter; Sea Tigers: unknown

Location Off coast of Sri Lanka

The Sea Tigers are the naval element of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Elam, or Tamil Tigers, an insurgency force conducting a longstanding war aimed at creating a separatist Tamil state in northern Sri Lanka. The naval force was founded in the mid-1980s, and went on to specialize in speedboat suicide attacks, fast patrol boat assaults, and small-scale amphibious landings. In these tactics they have been notably successful—at the time of writing the Sea Tigers have sunk over 30 Sri Lankan gunboats and one freighter. They have also proved elusive opponents—following an operation, the small craft are generally brought ashore and hidden in the jungle on trailers. They have experienced setbacks, however. In one engagement on October 20, 2006, the Sri Lankan navy destroyed nine rebel boats and reportedly killed over 170 Tamil Tiger insurgents. The Sea Tigers have an advanced structure and logistical network. Freighters are used to bring in supplies, which are transferred to shore in the fast patrol boats. They also have their own version of Special Forces—frogmen using rebreather apparatus have made attacks on shipping, in one case sinking a freighter at the Kankesanturai naval base. With these capabilities, the Sea Tigers are likely to be a thorn in the side of the Sri Lankan navy for years to come.

Sea Tiger suicide vessel
Sea Tiger suicide soldiers—known as Black Tigers—ride a patrol boat through shallow waters near the rebel-controlled town of Mullathivu in 2005.

